service, parsing traffic to create instant reports. This tool is available at *http://firestats.cc*.

GoAccess: For Linux administrators who want immediate insight into their websites, GoAccess is probably the best choice in the open source world. A great feature of this tool is that it can work in real time, which means that administrators can pull up a report by querying the service, on the fly. This report, however, is not in HTML format, but certainly gives enough information to know exactly what is happening on the Web server—which files are being accessed at that moment, the errors occurring with the Web engine at that time, etc. Besides this, it is capable of supporting the IPv6 protocol, and can also parse any custom log format. This makes it a must have tool, especially for parsing logs of network components and devices. It is available at *http://sourceforge.net/projects/goaccess*.

Web Forensik: While many analytics tools focus heavily on the website usage statistics and patterns, Web Forensik focuses more on the security angle of a website. It is specifically written for the Apache log style; however, with proper log file conversion, any Web server log file can be processed. Many Web developers don't have any insight into the security of their code. Web Forensik is capable of finding commonly known Web attacks such as cross-site scripting, cookie injection and SQL injection. During and after development, the team can subject code to such common attacks using penetration testing tools, and put the Web Forensik utility to work, to find which code files may have security loopholes. Besides this feature, it can also show output in a graphical form to create meaningful reports. The utility is available at *http://sourceforge.net/projects/webforensik/*.

AW Log Analyser: Although this tool is not exactly free, there is a 'Lite' version, which is open source. This tool focuses more on the search engine robots. As we know, each search engine traverses websites using pre-defined bots, which leave access trails in the Web log files. AW Log Analyser has a built-in parsing mechanism, which can find out whether or not the website was accessed, by each of more than 400 different search engines. This is important from the business perspective, to understand where to channel the marketing efforts. To serve this purpose better, it can list the pages that receive the most hits from visitors, but not by search engines, and vice versa. It can work in offline mode too, where multiple accumulated past log files can be processed to get historical trend reports. This tool is available at *http://www.alterwind.com/loganalyzer*.

WebLog Expert: This is again a semi-commercial tool, with a paid enterprise version and a free lite version. This is a traditional tool for users who want to perform basic log analysis on their Windows desktop, while the log files to be parsed can be either in IIS or Apache format. A unique feature of this tool is that it can perform reverse DNS lookups to try finding domain names of the source IP addresses found in the logs. It also contains a built-in database to map IP addresses to countries. This tool is available at *http://www.weblogexpert.com*.

A Web log analyser is an essential tool for Web administrators from the technology as well as business standpoint. While selecting an analyser, the focus should be on ease of use and the quality, as well as the details highlighted in the graphical report output. A powerful Web log analyser provides great insight into the customers accessing the website and their mind-sets, which makes these tools essential for decision-making.

Note: Tools mentioned in this article are purely to bring clarity to the subject of Web analytics. The order in which these tools are mentioned is not intended to undermine any tool's ratings or features.

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